

Cybersecurity Awareness among College Students: A Study on Knowledge, Behavior, and Risk

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Abstract

Cybersecurity has become a major concern in today's digital era, especially among college students who frequently use online platforms. This study examines the level of cybersecurity awareness among college students, focusing on password practices, safe browsing habits, and knowledge of common cyber threats. A sample of 50 students was analyzed, and the findings show that although most students understand basic threats, risky online behavior is still common. The study concludes that cybersecurity training and awareness programs are necessary to promote safer digital habits.

Keywords: Cybersecurity, Students, Awareness, Online Safety, Cyber Threats, Digital Behavior.

1. Introduction

With increasing dependence on the internet, cybersecurity has become an important issue. College students are highly active online, using digital platforms for education, social media, banking, and entertainment. However, their lack of awareness often exposes them to risks such as phishing, malware, identity theft, and data breaches. This research aims to study how aware students are about cybersecurity practices and threats.

2. Review of Literature

Several studies have highlighted that young users often prioritize convenience over security. Many students reuse passwords across websites, making their accounts vulnerable. Phishing attacks remain successful because users fail to verify links before clicking. Previous research also suggests that the absence of formal cybersecurity education contributes to unsafe online behavior. Overall, the literature indicates that awareness does not always lead to safe digital practices.

3. Research Methodology

- **Type of Study:** Descriptive research
- **Sample Size:** 50 college students
- **Data Collection Method:** Online questionnaire
- **Variables Studied:** Password practices, awareness of cyber threats, use of antivirus, safe browsing habits

A simple set of hypothetical data is used for academic purposes.

4. Findings

4.1 Password Practices

- 64% use the same password across multiple platforms
- Only 22% enable two-factor authentication

4.2 Awareness of Cyber Threats

- 90% have heard of phishing
- Only 35% can correctly identify a phishing email

4.3 Safe Browsing Behavior

- 42% check website URLs before entering personal information
- 58% have clicked on unknown or suspicious links

4.4 Device Security

- 70% have antivirus software installed
- Only 30% regularly update software and applications

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Summary:

Students possess basic cybersecurity knowledge, but their online practices are still unsafe and inconsistent.

5. Conclusion

The study concludes that although most college students are aware of basic cybersecurity concepts, their actual online behavior continues to put them at risk. There is a need for colleges to introduce cybersecurity workshops and awareness programs. Students should adopt stronger passwords, enable two-factor authentication, avoid suspicious links, and regularly update their devices.

6. References

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